



1 Guided literary analysis: unseen prose (Paper 1)

Paper 1 · Guided literary analysis · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Paper 1 asks you to produce a close analysis of an unseen prose passage, responding to a guiding question that points you toward a specific feature (e.g. narrative perspective, characterisation, tone). Your task is to build an argument about how the passage produces meaning and effect, using the guiding question as a lens rather than a checklist. Strong responses integrate narrative technique, diction, syntax and structure into a single line of interpretation, supported by precise textual evidence.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Guiding question: how does the writer present the narrator's isolation? A model sentence: 'The extended, unbroken syntax of the opening paragraph, with its chain of subordinate clauses trailing after the main verb, mimics the narrator's own inability to stop rehearsing the same thought, so that sentence structure itself becomes a symptom of the isolation the passage describes.' This links a concrete formal feature (syntax) directly to the guiding question (isolation) rather than merely labelling the device.

Quick check · multiple choice

In a Paper 1 guided literary analysis, the guiding question should be treated as:

- A A rigid list of every point that must be covered in order
- B A lens that focuses your argument on a specific aspect of the passage
- C A summary of the passage's plot that you must repeat
- D An optional suggestion that can be ignored if you have a better idea

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Read the following invented extract and respond to the guiding question: How does the writer convey the narrator's growing unease? 'The house had always creaked, but tonight it seemed to be counting something, each groan of the staircase arriving a beat too regular to be the wind. She told herself it was only the old wood settling, the way she had told herself the same thing every night that week, and she climbed the stairs anyway, one hand trailing the banister as though it might answer back.' Write a close analysis (using an introduction, developed body paragraphs, and a brief conclusion) that addresses the guiding question through specific textual detail. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

Introduction: state a clear thesis linking unease to a specific technique combination (e.g. sound imagery + repetition + syntax).

- Point 1: the personification/simile of the house 'counting' turns an ordinary domestic sound into something deliberate and threatening, foreshadowing danger.
- Point 2: repetition of 'told herself... told herself' signals a gap between conscious reassurance and instinctive fear, revealing self-deception as a coping mechanism.
- Point 3: the final image of a hand 'trailing the banister as though it might answer back' personifies an inanimate object, suggesting the narrator's unease has begun to distort her perception of her environment.
- Point 4: sentence length and the comma-linked clauses build a hesitant, accumulating rhythm that mirrors mounting dread rather than resolving it.
- Conclusion: tie the devices back to the guiding question, arguing unease is built cumulatively rather than through a single shock device.

Quick check answer

B. The guiding question focuses your interpretation on a particular aspect without limiting you to only that feature.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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